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Transformational wisdom

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Abstract

Transformational wisdom involves the application of knowledge, abilities, and attitudes to achieve a common good that makes a positive, paradigm-defying, meaningful, and potentially enduring transformative difference to the world for multitudes of people. There are various kinds of transformational wisdom, all of which can be contrasted with transactional wisdom, which is acting wisely merely in exchange for some kind of compensation. Pseudo-transformational wisdom is the appearance of transformational wisdom that disguises selfish and often narcissistic, Machiavellian, and even psychopathic intentions.

Keywords

Creativity, intelligence, other-transformational wisdom, self-transformational wisdom, transactional wisdom, transformational wisdom, wisdom

We write at a time when the possibilities for the future are, in some ways, ominous. Top leaders and aspirants for top leadership positions appear to show age-related cognitive loss (Ortega & Nirappil, 2024). Sociocultural and political polarization are rampant in the United States and throughout much of the world (Carothers & O'Donohue, 2019). Worldwide, intellectually bright leaders and their minions are using their intelligence, often darkly (Sternberg, 2024a), to sow discontent and discord. If the world wants to realize better possibilities than dissension and what appears to be a kind of metaphorical mental centrifugal force, then the world needs something that is largely absent from the leadership of today. It needs to recognize that what is important is not just "smart" behavior, but behavior that helps to create a better set of possibilities for the world (Glăveanu, 2023). What kind of personal attribute might offer such better possibilities? One such attribute certainly is wisdom, which offers some of the best possibilities for the future (see Copeland, 2023; Glăveanu, 2020, 2022, 2023, 2024; Kara-Yakoubian et al., 2023; Streib, 2024).

Wisdom, according to one conception, called a balance theory of wisdom, is the application of one's knowledge and skills to reach a common good; over the long-term as well as the short-term; by balancing one's own, others', and larger interests; through the infusion into one's decision-making and actions of positive

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ethical values (Sternberg, 1998, 2019c). (This conception will be elaborated upon later in the article.)

We recognize the difficulty of agreeing upon and then achieving a common good. Different people and groups may perceive, at least initially, different common goods and may have different values and weightings of values that lead them in different directions. For most world problems, only a fool or an autocrat would believe that there is an easily recognizable unique common good, and it just happens to be the one they recognize. Rather, part of wisdom is working diligently and sometimes in discord with others to achieve some consensus of a common good, with the realization that one can never know for sure what it is or whether any single common good or even multiple common goods exist. The best that people can do is to think reflectively and critically (Dewey, 1934), realizing that epistemic humility requires them, at least for real-world problems, to acknowledge that they never can be sure of having attained any "best" solution. Wisdom always involves recognizing some level of uncertainty that will haunt one, almost no matter what one does.

Wisdom can be applied at multiple levels of interaction, such as within a family, within a community, within or between nations, and so forth. We introduce in this article a concept we refer to as *transformational wisdom*, which is wisdom applied at a level that makes a positive, meaningful, and potentially enduring difference to the world as a whole, and in some way contributes to making the world a better place. We contrast transformational wisdom with *transactional wisdom*, which is wisdom that is motivated by an exchange of goods or services. For example, judges, therapists, and counselors may provide transactionally wise advice, usually at the individual level, in exchange for payment.

One might hope, in some ideal world, that all wisdom would be freely given. But most of those who spend many years developing their wisdom in a particular domain, such as teaching, law, medicine, science, business, or whatever, ultimately need to be compensated, just like anyone else. Presumably, those who study as preparation to give wise advice could not afford to do so were they not to be compensated in the future for the time they spent preparing to give the advice. Family members and friends may attempt to provide wise advice to each other in exchange for appreciation or some other token on the part of other family members. But their advice generally will not be at the level of an expert with years of training in giving professional advice.

The goal of this article is to elaborate upon the newly proposed construct of transformational wisdom, and to show its relationship with previously extant constructs, such as intelligence, creativity, and wisdom that is not transformational. People can be very intelligent, even brilliant, without being wise. Consider some examples.

Two of the most intelligent men of the 18th-century United States were Alexander Hamilton and Aaron Burr. Hamilton's accomplishments in his short life are legendary. He was born out of wedlock on the island of Nevis but managed to create a life that enabled him, among other things, to become a Revolutionary War hero, to serve as a delegate to the Congress of Confederation in Philadelphia, to found the Bank of New York, to fight for the abolition of slavery before most of his fellow citizens saw it as an issue, to coauthor *The Federalist Papers*, to establish the United States Mint, to become first Secretary of the United States Treasury, and much more. Hamilton's distinguished contributions to a country in which he was not even born have been noted in many ways, such as his portrait on the $10 bill and the naming of a Broadway musical after him.

Aaron Burr is less well-known to most people, but his record was also extremely distinguished. Burr was a Vice-President of the United States (during the first presidential term of Thomas Jefferson), was an officer during the American Revolutionary War, received his bachelor's degree from Princeton University at the age of 16, was a successful lawyer in

Albany, New York, founded a bank (the Manhattan Company), and had a distinguished political career—until he didn't.

Burr and Hamilton became at odds with each other, and Burr demanded that Hamilton publicly apologize for besmirching his honor. Hamilton refused. Burr and Hamilton agreed to a duel. Dueling was illegal in New York and as well in New Jersey, where the duel took place. They chose New Jersey because the punishment was not as severe as in New York. The rest of the story is history. Burr killed Hamilton. Burr's life then went downhill in pretty much every possible respect, and he eventually fled the United States.

Hamilton's and Burr's piercing intelligence (with Hamilton becoming a distinguished statesman despite his illegitimate birth in Nevis, a potential major stumbling block at the time, and Burr becoming distinguished but ending up being tried for treason for reasons unrelated to the duel) suggests, as have the careers of so many other brilliant individuals, that highly intelligent people can make what seem, in retrospect, to be incredibly foolish decisions. Both Hamilton and Burr were followed by foolish decisions throughout their lives, with Hamilton paying blackmail for an affair with a married woman (who probably was in on the blackmailing) and Burr seemingly turning against his own country. Why do smart people make foolish decisions, not necessarily just once, but over and over again?

A number of accounts have been proposed for why smart people make foolish decisions in their lives (see, e.g. Aczel, 2019; Sternberg, 2002, 2004). Some foolish decisions are for low stakes: One makes an impulse buy that one later regrets. Others are for higher stakes: One marries someone for their physical appearance, failing adequately to take into account their inner qualities. But some are for very high stakes. The decision of the administration of George W. Bush to invade Iraq was based on information that was almost entirely false and without merit (Doherty & Kiley, 2023). Today, as we write, wars are raging in Ukraine and in Israel/Palestine. Tens of thousands have died, for what exactly? Vladimir Putin is under indictment by the World Court, with an international arrest warrant issued against him (International Criminal Court, 2023). The prime minister of Israel is under indictment in Israel, and the United States has elected as president another man who appears to have sought political office in part to avoid imprisonment for felonies (McGreal, 2023). For whatever reasons, people find toxic but charismatic leaders appealing (Kellerman, 2004; Lipman-Blumen, 2005, 2006). It may be that such leaders represent a sort of collective id of their followers—the followers wish they could do, and get away with, what the toxic leader is doing.

The educational system in the United States and in much of the world elsewhere places great emphasis on the kind of intelligence measured by conventional intelligence tests and their proxies. But what if this kind of intelligence is not adequate for solving the kinds of problems the world presents today and will present in the future? IQs rose 30 points during the 20th century (Flynn, 2012, 2016), but whatever the rising IQs accomplished, they do not seem to have been particularly helpful in solving, or even in addressing the serious problems the world faces today, such as with regard to poverty, hunger, homelessness, economic disparities, pollution, global climate change, or wanton violence, to name a few. Something important seems to be missing because not only the quality of people's lives, but the lives themselves—are being affected. Having intelligence does not guarantee that one has wisdom.

Creativity might seem to be another potential answer to today's problems. But too much of creativity today is being used darkly, or for negative rather than positive purposes (Cropley et al., 2008, 2010; James et al., 1999; James & Taylor, 2010; Kapoor & Kaufman, 2022a, 2022b, 2022c). And there is nothing in the definition of creativity as novel and useful products or innovations (Kaufman & Sternberg, 2019) that ensures that creativity will be turned to

Table 1. Differences among intelligence (*g*), creativity, and wisdom.

Characteristic	Intelligence (*g*)	Creativity	Wisdom
Embedded into many educational systems through testing and instruction	x		
Widely accepted theory of construct	x		
Fairly easily measurable by multiple choice or short answer	x		
Generally accepted "right" and "wrong" answers on tests	x		
Speediness considered at least somewhat important	x	x	
Often measured by divergent thinking		x	
Often quite domain-specific		x	x
Often quite context-specific		x	x
Relevant primarily to judgments based on human values			x
Test items are culturally grounded	x	x	x
Folk conceptions of construct differ across cultures	x	x	x
Century-long tradition of study in psychology	x		
Centuries-long tradition of study in philosophy			x
Judgments made on the basis of novelty of answer		x	x
Ethics are *not* a basis for judgment	x	x	
Focus on human clashes and conflicts			x

positive use. Creativity is not going to solve world problems because it is too easy and often well-rewarded to use it for negative, or even toxic purposes (Sternberg, Soleimani-Dashtaki, & Power, 2024). Creativity can be taught (O'Hara & Sternberg, 2000–2001), but what results from the instruction does not always produce the kinds of positive contributions the teachers may have hoped for.

Wisdom, different from intelligence, is oriented toward a common good. In a highly interconnected world where decisions in one place can affect decisions in other places at a great distance, the intelligence needed to advance one's own interests or the interests of others like oneself (in physical appearance, ideology, nationality, religion, political party, or whatever) is not only potentially narrow and short-sighted, but also potentially harmful.

In a series of studies, Sternberg and his colleagues studied whether wisdom is just another word for classical "intelligence," perhaps dressed up in a slightly fancier form. Sternberg (1985) studied implicit theories of intelligence, creativity, and wisdom in groups of professors of art, business, and philosophy, as well as laypersons. Averaged across fields, correlations between ratings of behaviors for intelligence and wisdom had a median of .68, with a range of .42 to .78. Correlations of creativity and wisdom had a median of .27, with a range of −.24 to .48. (Business professors viewed creativity and wisdom as negatively correlated). So, the participants viewed intelligence as well as creativity as related to wisdom, but not as the same thing.

An alternate view to both the view of general intelligence and the implicit-theories results, presented by Sternberg (2021), characterizes intelligence as having to fit into an adaptive framework that is adaptive not only for oneself, but for the world in which one lives. Sternberg refers to this quality as *adaptive intelligence*, to distinguish it from the *general intelligence* measured by conventional intelligence tests. Sternberg (2019a) has pointed out that general intelligence provides little or no protection from foolish or toxic behavior. Stanovich (in press) further has noted that general intelligence is relatively independent of myside bias, meaning that people of any level of intelligence are prone to use their intelligence to justify whatever beliefs they have, no matter how foolish or toxic those beliefs may be.

Table 1 shows how intelligence and creativity are different from, and insufficient for wisdom.

The table presents some of the characteristics that differentiate wisdom from intelligence and from creativity. The table shows that, although there is overlap, there is also a substantial amount of difference. Wisdom differs from intelligence and creativity, in particular, in its role in the resolution of difficult and enduring human clashes and conflicts.

Schooling needs to teach for more than intelligence and even creativity. Some scholars have proposed that what is missing in education, in particular, and society, in general, is wisdom, which can be define as the "capacity of judging rightly in matters relating to life and conduct; soundness of judgement in the choice of means and ends; sometimes, less strictly, sound sense, esp. in practical affairs: opposed to folly" (Oxford English Dictionary, 2024). Whether with regard to qualities, judgments, or actions, wisdom would somehow seem to be different from intelligence. It offers possibilities for a better world that are unique (Streib, 2024).

Sternberg, Soleimani-Dashtaki, and Baydil (2024) studied wisdom in scientific contexts in part to see whether it differed from general intelligence. They presented scientific judgment problems in which a new product was being proposed that, while useful, might have undesirable effects if adopted. For example, a new nutritional supplement has been proposed that came through well on safety tests but about which there are potential questions, such as regarding longer-term effects and side effects of the supplement. The participants were asked to pose the questions an investor should ask before investing a substantial amount of money in production of the product. Thus, the product might make a truly positive difference, or it might not. The investigators found that scores on the scientific-wisdom test were correlated with scores on tests of scientific reasoning and scientific creativity but were not consistently correlated with scores on various tests of fluid intelligence. The results suggested that scientific wisdom is not merely a manifestation of fluid intelligence.

Giftedness is another construct that differs from wisdom, although they have some similarities. People with transformational giftedness aim to make a positive impact through innovation, social change, or other forms of significant contribution. They create better possibilities for the world. This approach emphasizes the common good and encourages individuals to seek a higher purpose beyond personal success (Sternberg et al., 2021). Transformationally gifted people are not necessarily wise, because wisdom requires deeply developed ethical, practical, and reasoning decision-making skills. A gifted person has a special talent in an area and wants to use it for special intentions, although not necessarily wise ones.

Susan Sophia James founded a concept she called Transformational Wisdom (Transformational Wisdom, n.d.). However, the concept she introduced differs from what is discussed in this paper. She provides tools and training that help people cultivate meaning, harmony, and balance in everyday life, regardless of their challenges.

Our article will focus on *fully transformational wisdom*, which is wisdom—the seeking of a common good by ethically balancing one's own with others' interests and higher-level interests over the long- as well as the short-term (Sternberg, 1998)—that can be viewed as satisfying 12 conditions:

1. *Large scope*. The wisdom potentially helps to create a better world, not just for one person, or those in a family or a group, but for a diverse multitude of stakeholders who, over the long-term, will benefit from the wisdom.
2. *Paradigm-defying*. The wisdom transmutes the order of things in some domain. It is not merely the basis of a balanced decision that helps to achieve a common good, but also a means of "stirring things up"—by redirecting the way people think about things from a dominant world view. It is analogous to what Sternberg (1999) referred to as

paradigm-breaking creativity that redirects or reinitiates the order of things (see also Kuhn, 2012).

3. *Interactional*. The wisdom does not inhere within the person but, as is the case for all wisdom, is a person x task x situational context interaction. That is, people are transformationally wise not only as a result of who they are, but also of what they do and where/when they do it (Sternberg et al., 2023) on a large scale. Transformational wisdom is thus always contextualized with respect to what needs to be done, and where and when it needs to be done.
4. *Process*. Transformational wisdom is a process rather than an end state; people strive to reach it but, ultimately, there is always more that can be done and that can be done better.
5. *Big W*. The wisdom is approaching the level of "Big W" (Sternberg & Karami, 2021), which is analogous to "Big C" creativity (J. C. Kaufman & Beghetto, 2009). That is, it matters to the world at a high level, although not necessarily an historic one. Wisdom that approaches but does not quite reach this level is referred to as proto-transformational later in this article. Some examples of transformationally wise people might include Winston Churchill, Abraham Lincoln, Mahatma Gandhi, Nelson Mandela, Mother Teresa, Martin Luther King, Jr., and Malala Yousafzai, among many others.
6. *Formulation, implementation, and communication across sociocultural barriers*. The wisdom transcends small-scale settings, such as a psychotherapy session, courtroom, or state legislative body in that it applies to highly diverse individuals and groups in varied sociocultural settings. It is *not* wisdom merely to benefit homogeneous group of like-minded people.
7. *Requires a team*. Whereas individual wisdom can be formulated and implemented by a single individual (e.g. psychotherapist, social worker, teacher, judge, CEO), transformational wisdom inevitably requires a collective effort—people working together to implement sociocultural change. The most well-known transformationally wise individuals may have come up with wise ideas on their own, but the implementation of those ideas always required the creation of, and subsequent action by, a team.
8. *Requires skills in inspiration and forming of one or more coalitions*. One needs to inspire others to join in what can be seen, at least by some, as a futile crusade.
9. *Requires strategies for overcoming inevitable obstacles*. Wisdom on the transformational scale virtually always encounters resistance, often, stiff and widespread resistance, and transformationally wise individuals and groups need strategies for overcoming that resistance.
10. *Requires a big picture and the ability to see into the very long-term, as the stakes are so high*. One needs to see not only the big picture of one's proposals, but also how those proposals will play out over the long term and what kinds of unexpected negative effects may arise.
11. *Requires willingness and courage to take what often are high levels of risk*. To be transformationally wise requires a high level of risk-taking that few people, even many wise people, are willing to take.
12. *In the balance of intra-personal, interpersonal, and extra-personal interests, extra-personal interests may take on a larger role than in a typical wise judgment*. The transformationally wise individual must put the interests of the whole as primary in their thinking.

One might ask whether wisdom, of any kind, is practical in today's world. How many people even want a common good, rather than a good

just for themselves and people like themselves? Some populist candidates for top offices are running openly racist, xenophobic, and ideological and religious platforms that are designed to appeal to certain groups at the expense of others (Eksi, 2021; Rattansi, 2020; Stewart, 2017). What places does wisdom have in a world that often seems to prefer candidates who are, at best, lacking in wisdom, and at worst, toxic? Our view is that, if the world is to survive, it has little choice but to create an educational system that values wisdom over toxicity and blatant hatred. The denigration of wisdom does not come out of nowhere. In a review of basal readers published between the beginning of the 19th and 20th centuries, it was found that ethical and wisdom-based content decreased monotonically (steadily) while content designed to shore up skills for taking standardized tests increased (Sternberg, 2019b).

We have no doubt that the application of wisdom to the everyday world faces increasing and severe challenges (Glück et al., 2019). And yet, what is the alternative? We need to draw on theories of wisdom to make the world better and to reduce demagoguery and hatred.

Before we present our own theory of wisdom, it would be helpful to review some previous theories, so we can then show how our theory builds on past work.

Theories of Wisdom

There are diverse extant theories of wisdom. Some, although certainly not all of the major psychological theories of wisdom are summarized in Table 2. The table shows each theory, the elements of the theory, and an example of the theory in action. These theories have served as intellectual antecedents of the notion of transformational wisdom. These theories include:

1. The theory of the pragmatics of life proposed by Paul Baltes and his colleagues (e.g. Baltes & Smith, 2008; Baltes & Staudinger, 1993, 2000).
2. The balance theory of wisdom (Sternberg, 1998, 2019c),
3. The three-dimensional model of Ardelt (2003, 2004; Ardelt et al., 2018; see also Clayton & Birren, 1980).
4. The MORE theory of wisdom (Glück & Bluck, 2013; Kunzmann & Glück, 2019).
5. The H.E.R.O.(E) model of Webster (2003, 2007; Webster et al., 2013)
6. The contextual model of Yang (2008).
7. The self-transcendence model of Aldwin et al. (2019)
8. The Polyhedron Theory of Wisdom (PMW) of Karami et al. (2020)
9. The common theory of wisdom of Grossmann, Weststrate, Ardelt, et al. (2020)
10. The integrative model of Glück and Weststrate (2022)
11. The "tree-of-philosophy" (TOP) theory of wisdom of Sternberg (2023)

Recent reviews of these theories can be found in Glück and Weststrate (2022), Grossmann, Weststrate, Ferrari, and Brienza (2020), Sternberg and Glück (2019, 2022a, 2022b), and Sternberg and Karami (2021). Because the TOP theory of wisdom underlies the notion of transformational wisdom presented in this article, it is summarized in more detail in Table 3.

The tree-of-philosophy theory is different from many contemporary integrative theories. Many recent theories of wisdom seek to synthesize recent psychological efforts to comprehend wisdom. In contrast, the TOP theory attempts to synthesize the efforts of multiple millennia of inquiry in philosophy. Indeed, the term "philosophy" refers to "love of wisdom." Philosophy has sometimes been characterized as having branches, much like a tree. Although there is no perfect agreement on what these branches of the tree should be (Blackburn, 2008, Ryan, 2013; Sternberg, 2023), the tree of philosophy usually has as branches, at the very least, metaphysics—including epistemology (what is known and unknown) and ontology (being

Table 2. Major extant psychologically-based theories of wisdom.

1. Baltes (pragmatics of life)	Factual knowledge; Procedural knowledge; Lifespan contextualism; Relativism of values; Awareness and management of uncertainty	For example, an individual realizes that others may have a different value system from oneself
2. Sternberg (balance)	Seeking of a common good; By balancing interests of self, others, and society; Over the long- and short-terms; Through the infusion of positive ethical values; By adapting to, shaping, and selecting environments	For example, an individual realizes that a proposed solution may be more helpful to some than to others over the short-term, but that over the long term, it will best help everyone achieve their goals
3. Ardelt (three-dimensional)	Cognitive; Reflective; Affective	For example, an individual's compassion for the persecuted helps lead them to aid a persecuted population that others are ignoring
4. Glück and Bluck (MORE)	Mastery; Openness; Reflectivity; Emotional regulation and empathy	For example, an individual is open to points of view on an important problem in their corporation that they previously did not take into account
5. Webster (H.E.R.O.(E))	Humor; Emotional regulation; Reminiscence/reflectiveness; Openness to experience; Critical life experiences	For example, an individual is about to lose their temper and then realizes the absurdity to the situation and instead smiles, saving them from a public embarrassment
6. Aldwin (self-transcendence)	Self-transcendence	For example, an individual finds within themselves levels of altruism and compassion that they previously thought were inaccessible to them
7. Yang	Integration; Embodiment; Positive effects	For example, an individual is able to integrate their experiences in various cultures to come up with a solution to a problem that has vexed members of their multicultural group

(continued)

Table 2. (Continued)

8. Grossmann et al. (common)	Balance of viewpoints; Epistemic humility; Context adaptability; Multiple perspectives	For example, an individual realizes that, despite their expertise, their students often have better ideas than they do because the students are less entrenched in their thinking
9. Karami et al. (polyhedron)	Knowledge; Reflectivity and self-regulation; Pro-social behaviors and moral maturity; Openness and tolerance; Sound judgment and creativity; Dynamic balance and synthesis	For example, an individual is very angry at another but realizes the importance of self-restraint because the conflict they are having will not be resolved by displays of anger
10. Glück and Weststrate (integrative)	Knowledge; Metacognitive capacities; Self-reflection; *moderated by* Exploratory orientation; Concern for others; Emotion regulation	For example, an individual knows that a friend is in trouble and that although their offer of help poses some risk to them personally, it is the right thing to offer to help nevertheless
11. Sternberg (tree of philosophy)	Epistemological element; Ontological element; Ethical element; Logical element; Aesthetic element; Hermeneutic element; Axiological element	For example, an individual becomes tolerant of a group that they were brought up to disrespect, and realizes that their upbringing had led them on a bad track with regard to treating other people fairly

Notes:
(1) The theory of the pragmatics of life proposed by Paul Baltes and his colleagues (e.g. Baltes & Smith, 2008; Baltes & Staudinger, 1993, 2000).
(2) The balance theory of wisdom (Sternberg, 1998, 2019c).
(3) The three-dimensional model of Ardelt (2003, 2004; Ardelt et al., 2018; see also Clayton & Birren, 1980).
(4) The MORE theory of wisdom (Glück & Bluck, 2013; Kunzmann & Glück, 2019).
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(9) The Polyhedron Theory of Wisdom (PMW) of Karami et al. (2020).
(10) The integrative model of Glück and Weststrate (2022).
(11) The "tree-of-philosophy" (TOP) theory of wisdom of Sternberg (2023)

Table 3. Elements of tree-of-philosophy (TOP) theory of wisdom.

Branch of tree of philosophy	Description of branch	Example of branch
Epistemology	Role of knowledge in wisdom	Individual knows what they know, what they do not know, what they can know, and what they cannot know with regard to the state of the world
Ontology	Role of being and resulting action in wisdom	Individual seeks course of action that maximizes common good; by balancing their own, others', and larger interests; over the long- as well as the short-term
Ethics	Role of ethical and moral precepts in wisdom	Individual acts in ways guided by positive ethical values
Logic	Role of logical and rational thinking in wisdom	Individuals' beliefs and actions are based on an internally consistent set of assumptions and follow reasonably from those assumptions
Aesthetics	Role of beauty in wisdom—wise processes and products have intrinsic beauty	Individual seeks a solution to problems, and appreciates solutions, that have an intrinsic beauty to them
Hermeneutics	Good judgment as a necessary basis for wisdom	Individual judges work on the basis of its quality, not merely its agreement with their beliefs or ideology
Axiology	A value system that is appropriate, fair, and equitably applied, taking into account that others may have legitimate value systems	Individual's value system takes into account and respects the fact that different people and groups have different legitimate values as well as interests

translated into action)—plus ethics (what is morally or ethically justifiable), logic (what is internally consistent), aesthetics (what is beautiful), hermeneutics (making good judgments), and axiology (having a well-developed and justifiable set of values). According to this theory, a wise person seeks a common good; by balancing their own, others', and larger interests; over the long- as well as the short-term; through the infusion of positive ethical values.

It turns out, however, that any theory of wisdom needs to take into account two complications—general versus personal wisdom and dispositional versus situational wisdom, as illustrated in Table 4.

The first complication is that there is a difference between what might be called "general wisdom" and what might be called "personal wisdom" (Ferrari & Weststrate, 2013; Staudinger, 2019). People who are generally wise in their interactions with others are not necessarily wise in their own personal lives, and vice versa. For example, many wise leaders, such as Martin Luther King and Nelson Mandela, have had somewhat serious issues in their personal lives.

The second complication is that wisdom is not merely dispositional, but often also situational (Brienza et al., 2017; Grossmann, 2021). That is, people are often wise in some situations, but not in others. For example, they may be wise when they do not respond emotionally to a situation, but then act impulsively and even foolishly when they become emotionally overwrought. A full account of wisdom needs to

Table 4. Aspects of wisdom.

	General	Personal
Dispositional	A person who acts wisely with others across varied situations	A person who acts wisely in their own life across varied situations
Situational	A person who acts wisely with others in specific situations but not others	A person who acts wisely in their own life in specific situations but not others

take into account both the issue of general versus personal wisdom and dispositional versus situational wisdom. These, of course, are not dichotomies: People probably combine varied levels of personal and general wisdom, and some may be dispositionally wiser than others, with fluctuations occurring over varied situations.

Kaplan (1964) and Maslow (1954, 1966) came to a similar conclusion, sometimes called the Law of the Hammer. It is that if the only tool one has is a hammer, it is tempting to treat everything as though it were a nail. Sometimes the old saw is put in terms of the idea that if one gives a carpenter a hammer, he will find something to nail. Psychologists, except perhaps for behaviorists, tend to look for explanations of human behavior inside the psyche of the individual, so when seeking to understand human behavior, they tend to look for psychological constructs, often internal traits, that might explain the behavior. They find traits the way the carpenter finds nails.

What is problematic is that many behaviors are not well ascribed to inner psychological traits. For example, attempts to find the traits of people during World War II who saved persecuted persons, found that rescuers were not well characterized by typical Big 5 of other lists of personality traits. Rather, the rescuers tended to be more altruistic, reasoning with deeply internalized standards and moral values, had developed and manifested a sense of social responsibility, and further displayed a deep and pervasive concern for the plight of others than themselves (Midlarsky et al., 2005). These are not intrinsic personality traits; they are developed attitudes about right and wrong.

Transformational Versus Transactional Wisdom

Roughly speaking, wisdom can occur in various forms, including transactional, transformational, or pseudo-transformational, following notions of leadership laid down originally by Burns (1978) but then elaborated on by Bass and his colleagues (Bass, 1990, 1998, 1999; Bass & Avolio, 1993; Bass & Steidlmeier, 1999). These terms are explained here, and further depicted in Table 5. In every case, we start with the TOP theory of wisdom as a basis for understanding wisdom, and then elaborate upon different types of wisdom consistent with the TOP theory, remembering that wisdom can be general or personal, and situational or cross-situational.

One thing to keep in mind is the power of societal labeling. Wisdom, like intelligence and creativity (Sternberg, 2018a), lies in a person x task x situation interaction. A person viewed as wise in one society may be viewed as a fool or even as toxic in another, with Socrates, as always, being the classic case of a wise person forced to drink poison because he was viewed as toxic rather than wise. Alan Turing foresaw many of the developments that have come to be developed in computing and devised the Turing test, stating that a computer could be classified as "intelligent" when it could deceive humans into believing it was itself human. Yet, Turing was humiliated and punished by the British government for being gay. So, the question

Table 5. Kinds of transactional and transformational wisdom.

Kind of wisdom	Description of kind of wisdom	Example of kind of wisdom
Unidentified	A person is wise but is never identified as such	A wise person lives in autocratic state where making wise statements results in imprisonment or worse
Inert	A person is potentially wise but does not display their wisdom behaviorally in a way that is appreciated by others	A wise person lives among fools and their wise statements or actions are ignored or ridiculed
Transactional	A person is transactionally wise on an exchange-of-service basis	A person gives wise advice for a living (e.g. counselor) but does so only if compensated
Self (partially) transformational	A person is transformationally wise for their own (intra-personal) well-being and life course	A person is transformationally wise in respect to self-actualization but not in respect to other people
Other (partially) transformational	A person is transformationally wise for others' (inter-personal) well-being and life courses	A person is transformationally wise in respect to helping others to self-actualize but not in respect to themselves
Generally (partially) transformational	A person is transformationally wise on extra-personal matters but not necessarily intra- or inter-personal ones	A person is transformationally wise in handling assets or business matters, but not necessarily as respects interactions with people
Fully transformational	A person is transformationally wise on intra-, inter-, and extra-personal matters	A person is transformationally wise across domains of life pursuits
Pre-transformational	Person shows signs of the potential for transformational wisdom, but is inexperienced or cognitively/affectively not ready yet to show transformational wisdom	A person is caring, compassionate, empathetic, considerate, and kind, but has not yet learned how to translate these dispositions into transformationally wise actions
Proto-transformational	A person is in the process of becoming transformationally wise but is not quite "there" yet, or is transformationally wise only in very limited situations	A person is on the path to becoming transformationally wise but has not quite reached some threshold
Para (partially) transformational	A person gives what appears to be transformationally wise counsel, but it is not clear that it will be wise in the long- as well as the short-term	A person has ideas that appear to be transformationally wise, but it is not yet clear where those ideas will go in the long term, as they may also appear to contain within them seeds of potential harm
Post-transformational	A person recognizes when it is time to let go and let others take over in positions enabling them to be transformationally wise and to act on that wisdom	A president or CEO of a company realizes that their best work is behind them and that it is time to retire and let others take over the responsibilities they have had
Pseudo-transformational	A person appears to be transformationally wise, but the appearance hides dark-triad motivations and potentially toxic aspirations	A person pretends to be transformationally wise and fools others, but is Machiavellian, narcissistic, and psychopathic

arises of what grounds one has to believe that society has the right to label people as wise or unwise. In some countries today (Saudi Arabia and Iran), for example, gay acts still can lead to the death penalty. We would like to believe that there is some higher power that dictates what actions are "wise" or "unwise," but in the end, they are a labeling phenomenon that depends on where and when a person lives and what they happen to do that is being judged.

Lack of Wisdom

The branches of the Tree of Philosophy (TOP) theory (Sternberg, 2023) suggest qualities of judgment and action that are essential for wisdom. People who lack wisdom: (a) do not know what they do not know, and probably do not much care; (b) may or may not produce wise solutions, but if they do, do not enact them; (c) lack a developed ethical foundation for their actions; (d) often think illogically; (e) fail to appreciate the beauty of wisdom in their lives; (f) misinterpret information; and (g) have values that are lacking in integrity, or few values at all.

Unidentified Wisdom

One cannot declare oneself wise. Part of wisdom, whether in the TOP theory (Sternberg, 2023) or in other theories, such as the common model of Grossmann, Weststrate, Ardelt, et al. (2020), is epistemic humility—recognizing one's own limitations. The wiser one is, the more one recognizes one's limitations. This situation creates something of a paradox for self-assessment measures of wisdom (see Webster, 2019). In particular, people who describe themselves as higher in wisdom may actually be lower in wisdom, because their high ratings indicate a lack of intellectual humility. Such instances may be examples of the Dunning–Kruger effect, whereby less competent people tend to view their competence at a higher level than others do (Kruger & Dunning, 1999).

Sadly, in many societies today, the wisest people end up not only not being identified as such but risk being isolated or even punished. For example, expressing dissent regarding governmental policies or anything interpreted as dissent is today severely punished in Russia (Associated Press, 2023; Coalson, 2023; Litvinova, 2024).

The trend to suppress dissent is hardly new: Wise though he may have been, Socrates was executed because he was viewed as corrupting the young. In some societies today, wisdom leads one to similar fates, or much worse, as Alexei Navalny and many other seemingly wise Russians have found out the hard way, knowing, like Socrates, the risks they were taking. Human nature apparently has gotten no better since ancient times.

Inert Wisdom

Inertly wise people are identified as wise but not as acting upon their wisdom. They may have cognitive, metacognitive, affective, and personality traits associated with wisdom, but their actions are not perceived as wise. Inert wisdom can be associated with someone who "talks the talk but does not walk the walk" or with someone who just does not want to expend the effort or trouble to think wisely, even though they can do so. But there are other, perhaps more insidious reasons as well why wisdom might remain inert.

One reason is that a wise person may have to choose between displaying wisdom and going to prison or worse, as happens in some autocracies or other governments that do not permit dissent. A second reason is that a company for which one works may suppress wisdom because it is not interested in a common good but rather in corporate profits. A third reason is that a political or ideological group may engage in groupthink (Janis, 1972), whereby those who do not conform to the norms and orthodoxy of a group are censured or forced out of the group. As Kuhn (2012) pointed out, scientists, with whom one frequently associates an unfettered search for truth, are at least as guilty of such censure as anyone else. They claim to like ideas

that depart from norms but often seem to like the ideas only if those ideas do not threaten them professionally and perhaps personally. And in religious societies, wisdom may be accepted only within the constraints allowed by the doctrine of the religion.

Transactional Wisdom

Transactional wisdom is wisdom in exchange for something—money, resources of some kind, praise, prestige, status, keeping one's job, professional or personal advancement, or whatever. The fact that the wisdom is transactional does not make it somehow worthless. Rather, its goal is the enhancement of one's position and stature in the world. The transactional nature of the wisdom may or may not affect the quality of the judgment. For example, one may hold back on some of one's ideas if one believes that they will lead to indifferent or even injurious personal or professional outcomes.

Much of wisdom is transactional. When a clinical psychologist, psychiatrist, social worker, or counselor offers therapy, it is usually in return for payment. The payment does not lower the quality of the wisdom, but it leaves the recipient of the advice knowing that they got the advice only because they paid for it; they may then feel differently from how they would feel were the advice freely given with no transaction. For example, they may feel that the wise advice was given not because the giver cared especially about the recipient, but rather, because the giver cared about receiving payment from the recipient. There may be things that family members or friends would tell a recipient of advice that a hired counselor would not tell the recipient because the hired counselor sees those things as outside preset bounds that are allowed for them in the position they are in.

Even when professionals are transactional, it matters how they come across to those to whom they are giving advice, counsel, or directions. Some professionals come across as "doing it for the money," others because they love what they are doing and care about the people whom they are teaching, advising, or supervising. How effective one will be in transmitting transactional wisdom may depend as much on one's apparent motivation for giving the advice or direction as it depends on the advice or direction itself. Motivation, then, matters for translation into wise (and other) behavior (Dweck et al., 2004).

Transformational Wisdom

Transactionally wise people often are more motivated by extrinsic motivators (money, externally rewarded accomplishment, credit, attainment of fame, or power). Transformationally wise people often are more motivated by intrinsic motivators, such as attaining purpose and meaning through their actions. But transformationally wise people may be transactionally wise as well. Often, they need transactional wisdom to figure out how to get their ideas accepted by others. Similarly, people who are transactionally wise, for the most part, may have ideas that are transformationally wise and that help to transform society as a whole.

Transformational wisdom can be of several kinds, namely, self-transformational, other-transformational, pseudo-transformational, pre-transformational, proto-transformational, and fully transformational. Only fully transformational wisdom encompasses all aspects of transformational wisdom. The other kinds are incomplete and partial–they have elements of transformational wisdom, but do not have all its elements.

Self (Partially) Transformational Wisdom. Some people live wisely. They are prudent in their personal lives. They save, they spend within their means, they take care of their health, they stay away from harmful substances, and generally, they take responsibility for themselves without imposing on others. They may make mistakes, but they learn from them. They try to improve themselves and their interactions with the world, eventually becoming what Maslow (1954, 1962; see also S. B. Kaufman, 2001) referred to as self-actualized. On the one hand, they are wise in the sense of achieving balance and minimizing their negative impact on the

world; on the other hand, they are not fully transformational because their main concern is themselves and their own well-being.

In a society that emphasizes personal well-being and happiness, self-transformational wisdom may be viewed as an ultimate goal, in the same way, that, for some, the advantage of creativity is that it can be turned to increasing one's happiness and well-being (J. C. Kaufman, 2023). The problem is that if everyone looks out only for themselves, no matter how well they do it, but not for others, a society may end up with a tragedy of the commons, whereby each individual's advantage translates into a collective disadvantage.

Self-transformation, then, is important; but if it fails to take into account the needs of others, it may create a tragedy of the commons from which there may be no turning back. Such a tragedy is occurring in the world today with respect to the hydrocarbons that result from our making life easier for ourselves, but that have set us on a dangerous course of promoting global climate change.

Other (Partially) Transformational Wisdom. Albert Einstein offered the world nuggets of world-class wise advice, such as "I believe in one thing—that only a life lived for others is a life worth living," "Life is like riding a bicycle. To keep your balance, you must keep moving," and "If you can't explain it simply, you don't understand it well enough," but his personal life was something else altogether. He treated his wives terribly (Oyler, 2015) and was apparently something of a failure as a father (Smith, 1996). The list of individuals who offered wise advice to others, but had spectacular failures in their personal lives, is long, and includes as well the celebrated American author, Mark Twain (Samuel Clemens; Zacks, 2016), and, of course, Elvis Presley, who practically invented rock-'n-roll but lived the latter part of his life in trauma. As Staudinger (2019) and others have noted, there is a great difference between being generally wise in giving advice to others and being wise in one's own life. People can be transformationally wise in changing others' lives and yet make a mess of their own lives. These individuals have the capacity for transformational wisdom—they just do not apply it to their own lives. Wisdom is often domain-specific, so that wisdom in interpersonal situations is not necessarily relevant to intrapersonal situations, and vice versa.

Generally (Partially) Transformational. Wisdom is usually thought of in terms of dealing with other people, but it also can apply to dealings with organizational entities. For example, one of the wisest investors in the history of the United States almost certainly would be Warren Buffett (Dolan, 2023; Schroeder, 2009). There are many books on how people can become wise stewards of their (and other people's) money, as Buffett has been. That wisdom cannot be simply condensed into rules, as books of Buffett's "rules" suggest, is shown by the fact that those who have read the various books on Buffett's strategies seem not to have reaped the rewards he has. There is no simple magic formula or recipe. One might not think of investing as requiring wisdom, but in being wise in his investing, Buffett has made a fortune for himself, for many of his investors, and for the reputation of his firm and of the United States for having in its midst such a wise investor showing great prudence and deep reflection.

Fully Transformational. Fully transformational wisdom involves giving back to the world on a grand scale. Characteristics of problems drawing upon fully transformational wisdom are shown in Table 6. The fully transformational individual squarely addresses such problems. There of whom there are a number of famous and very well-known examples of such individuals–Abraham Lincoln, Martin Luther King, Nelson Mandela, Mahatma Gandhi, Malala Yousafzai, Mother Teresa, to name a few. One could quibble about one or another aspect of their lives, but not much about the tremendous impact all have had on the world in terms of working to transform it into a better place.

Transformational wisdom requires excellent judgment, but even more, it requires the motivation to use this judgment in the service of the

Table 6. Characteristics specifically of problems drawing upon *fully transformational wisdom*.

Characteristic	Example
The problems require achievement not only of a common good, but also one that is transformative at some level	Negotiations lead to an autocrat stepping down and a nation moving toward democracy
The problems addressed are for relatively high stakes—the solutions are consequential	The solution will take a major step toward alleviating economic inequality among citizens of a nation
The problems addressed affect substantial numbers of people	A nation realizes that the only alternative to conquest by an aggressive foreign power is to go to war
The problems addressed typically are highly emotionally laden and thus highly susceptible to partisan, ideological, economic, cultural, or other biases	A nation that calls itself a democracy recognizes that its system of government greatly favors one racial or ethnic group over others and decides to create a more just system of government
Implementation of a solution to the problem will be unusually difficult because of differing value or other judgmental systems of stakeholders	A legislative body decides to raise taxes substantially on very wealthy individuals in order to increase resources available to the nation
People have widely varying differences in how they define the problem facing them all, realizing that the way the problem is defined will greatly affect how it is solved	A former president of a country is put on trial for crimes, with some people believing the trial is a political persecution and others believing it is a criminal prosecution
The problem cannot be quickly solved, and often changes in the process of solving it	An attempt to wipe out a national enemy becomes difficult because people have different ideas about who the enemies are, and the people who become enemies change over time
The solution to the problem, even if achieved toward a common good, leaves some stakeholders upset and distraught	In a transformational wisdom problem, there is often no solution that, at least in the short term, seems good to everyone, and indeed, is good for everyone

world. People may be wise in the context of their lives, but not direct this wisdom toward making the world a better place to live. To a large extent, this is a decision as much as it is any kind of ability.

Being fully transformationally wise is very challenging because the personal rewards often are so slim. Politicians who are elected to national office—at least in current times—seem not to be elected for their wisdom. If anything, many of them seem more foolish or even toxic than wise. It is difficult to think of any occupation in which there are direct rewards, at least in current times, for being transformationally wise. Companies tend to be more concerned about their profits. Many prestigious universities hire faculty whose research gains prominence or gets attention—deserved or not—more than they hire faculty who will have wise advice to offer to students, or even to other faculty. Negotiators for businesses or even for countries often are expected to place the interests of whomever they represent first. The scarcity of transformational wisdom likely is not because people cannot do it, but rather, because the incentives for expressing and acting upon it are so slim.

Pre-Transformational Wisdom and Proto-Transformational Wisdom. One cannot expect young people to be transformationally wise. They often do not have the life experience. Rather, they are in the process of acquiring that life experience. Young people with special potential to become transformationally wise are ones who show the characteristics that theories of wisdom (see Sternberg & Glück, 2019) posit: compassion; empathy; sincerity; care, and concern for others; a theory of mind that encompasses openness to points of view other than one's own; appreciation of the value of diverse ways of thinking; acting and living; and a growth mindset. Individuals who are just starting out are potentially pre-transformational, and as they acquire knowledge, skills, and attitudes for transformational wisdom, they may become proto-transformationally wise—in the early stages of transformational wisdom. Many of those who are pre-transformationally wise will not make it to the level of proto-transformational wisdom, and many of those who are proto-transformationally wise will not make it to transformational wisdom. But they are givers who want to make the world better on a large scale (Glück & Tischler, 2021; Sternberg, 2024b).

Why do some people but not others go down the road of becoming pre-transformationally, proto-transformationally, and possibly even fully transformationally wise? We suggest that a confluence of factors can lead people down the road to fully transformational wisdom, for example:

1. *They find a cause about which they are passionate and to which they are committed.* People are not fully transformationally wise in the abstract. To even aspire to transformational wisdom, they need something that they care enough about to want to be transformational.
2. *They believe that whatever is being done with respect to the cause is insufficient and likely misdirected.* In order to aspire to be transformational, they have to see something wrong with the way things are being done.
3. *They have the self-efficacy to believe that, potentially, they could make a wise difference to the cause to which they are committed.* Many people will give up because they believe, for whatever reasons, that they do not have it in them to make a transformationally wise difference, either through lack of skills, or attitudes, or fit to the job at hand.
4. *They actively want to make a transformational difference to that cause.* In practice, abilities mean little in the absence of attitudes to utilize those abilities as needed (Sternberg, 2022; Sternberg, Soleimani-Dashtaki, & Baydil, 2024). The individuals who choose the road toward transformational wisdom do so because it is important to them to make a transformational difference to their cause.

5. *They are willing to undergo the preparation to be transformationally wise*. The road to transformational wisdom is long and may require educational preparation as well as "on-the-job" preparation. Those who wish to be transformationally wise are prepared to travel the long and challenging road.
6. *They have the ability as well as the attitude to think in nonentrenched ways and to analyze their nonentrenched thoughts*. Transformational wisdom requires creativity—it requires one to see a new path or set of paths toward solving a problem (Sternberg, 2018a). If one is entrenched, one will not be able to visualize such a path or set of paths. It also requires one to evaluate those thoughts to ensure they are truly creative in the way one wishes them to be.
7. *They have the resilience to confront and overcome the obstacles on the road to transformational wisdom*. Many might consider going down this road, only to withdraw before or soon after starting because people tend to be happy with the way things are, or if they are not, are reluctant to make the efforts needed to change. In some cases, being transformationally wise may cost one, one's reputation, freedom, or even, life.
8. *They wish to seek a common good*. To be truly transformational on a large scale, the path they follow must help to achieve a common good, not just a good for themselves or others they perceive to be like them, or a short-term or small good. Seeking a common good may be more than they wish to accomplish.
9. *They are willing to balance their own, others', and higher interests in an ethical way, over the long- as well as the short-term in high-stakes, world-changing situations*. In other words, they seek truly to be transformationally wise.
10. *They are willing to embrace and learn from failure*. Transformational wisdom does not typically come all at once. It is a process, and one that involves, at times, going down the wrong road, or going down the right road but too quickly or too slowly. They are prepared to learn from and correct their mistakes.
11. They are willing to make judgments that represent, to the best of their ability, courses of action that are based on truth, that are rational to the extent possible, and that seek a signficant long-term common good for as many stakeholders as possible.
12. They recognize the limitations of their own judgments, and that the beauty of transformational wisdom is that reaching it is a never-ending process that will not suddenly occur as the result of any single judgment or set of judgments.

Transformational wisdom thus possesses all the characteristics of the tree-of-wisdom (TOP) theory: *Epistemology*—knowing, to the best of one's ability, what is true; *Ontology*—knowledge turned into rightful action; *Ethics*—large-scale morality of judgment; *logic*—rationality; *Aesthetics*—beauty; *Hermeneutics*—good judgment; and *Axiology*—appropriate valuing.

If any reader had any doubt as to whether it was hard to achieve fully transformational wisdom, perhaps this discussion would help to allay their doubts. The road to fully transformational wisdom is long, arduous, and clearly not for everyone. It is much harder to be transformationally wise than to be, simply, wise because the scale is considerably larger.

Para (Partially) Transformational Wisdom. Sometimes, people seem to be wise, but it is not clear whether, in fact, they really are. At some level, we cannot be sure with anyone whether their ideas and actions will turn the world into a better place. But there are certain arenas where what appears to be wisdom later turns out to be something else entirely.

Politics is one such domain. As candidates, politicians promise one thing; as elected officials, they deliver another. A second domain in current times is artificial intelligence. Too often, positive promises have turned out with consequences that could have been better anticipated but weren't. Social media, for example, have proved to be harmful to children in unexpected ways. Generative AI is harming both people's intelligence and their creativity (Sternberg, in press). Medicines often have seemed to provide a better future, but some, insufficiently tested, have done the opposite.

Post-Transformational Wisdom. There comes a time when, no matter how wise and even transformationally wise one is, one needs to make way for a new generation of transformationally wise thinkers. One of the saddest things in life is to see leaders hold on to their positions who, however effective they may once may have been, no longer are effective or even, perhaps, metacognitively aware of their decaying effectiveness. Post-transformational wisdom requires one to know when to let go and make room for, and give a chance to, others.

Pseudo-Transformational Wisdom. Pseudo-transformational wisdom is the veneer of wisdom hiding foolishness or, often, toxicity beneath it. Oddly, the veneer is often very thin. Did anyone who thought reflectively actually believe that Adolf Hitler was going to make Germany a better place? Or that Joseph Stalin somehow had the key to making Russia better? Or Vladimir Putin? The list of pseudo-transformational demagogues is long, and some of them do not even hide their demagoguery or their malice. Rather, they make it their trademark, and there always seem to be people who believe they have received the short end of the stick who are ready to receive what they believe to be their "just desserts" by harming, and even gleefully harming, others.

Pseudo-transformational, toxic leaders have always been very attractive to many people (Lipman-Blumen, 2006) because they have a simple, compelling explanation of everything that is wrong—it is someone else's fault, and they are laughing at you. The line of many demagogues is that the demagogue's supporters have been played for suckers and now the demagogue is here to right things (Reeve, 2011).

As Stanovich (2009, 2021; Stanovich & West, 2000; Stanovich et al., 2013) has pointed out, lack of rational thinking is not the domain only of those who lack IQ points. Lack of rational thinking can be found everywhere, and to some extent, in everyone. It is difficult to be transformationally wise without well-developed critical thinking, because the risk of thinking so foolishly without knowing it is so great.

Pseudo-transformational wisdom seems to be a stock in trade of many authoritarian leaders. Some write or have ghost-written for them compendia of advice. Former Libyan dictator Moammar Gaddafi presented his thoughts in 1975 in *The Green Book*, which had quotations that were supposed to be wise, as reported by Roberts (2011), such as: "Mandatory education is a coercive education that suppresses freedom. To impose specific teaching materials is a dictatorial act." Then there is *Mao's Little Red Book*, or *Quotations from Chairman Mao Tse-tung*, once thought by some to be wise but no longer in the fashion it once was. Today, there are many books of Xi Jinping Thought as well, and then there is: "*The Hottest App in China [which] Teaches Citizens About Their Leader—and, Yes, There's a Test*" (Hernández, 2019).

There are other autocrats and would-be autocrats who acted similarly, not just abroad from where the authors live. Here in the United States, where the authors of this article reside, there is "*The King James Version of The Holy Bible with Patriotic Documents and Speeches of Donald J. Trump: The favorite documents of the 45th President of the United States, Donald J Trump*." Autocrats and would-be autocrats tend to take themselves very seriously, and regrettably, so do some of their devotees. People are very susceptible to following authority, often, blindly (Albright, 2018; Bandura, 2015; Levitsky & Ziblatt, 2018,

Figure 1. The path to and from fully transformational wisdom.
Note. The path to and from fully transformational wisdom goes from pre-transformational wisdom to post-transformational wisdom. Diverted paths are ones where an individual goes from proto-transformational wisdom to partially transformational self-, other-, merely general or para-transformational wisdom. The deviated path leads from pre-transformational wisdom to pseudo-transformational wisdom.

2023; Lewis, 1935/2014; Milgram, 1974/2009; Moghaddam, 2013, 2019; Orwell, 1950; Roth, 2005; Zimbardo, 2008).

There have been leaders who have written serious and reflective books, such as *Profiles in Courage* by Kennedy (2006), which won the Pulitzer Prize, *Long Walk to Freedom* by Mandela (1995), *Why We Can't Wait* by King (2000), and *I am Malala*, by Yousafzai (2016). But such books seem to be dwarfed by books that represent ramblings of pseudo-transformationally wise leaders full of the drug of power and the pretense of being wise.

Conclusion

Figure 1 shows the path from pre-transformational to proto-transformational to fully transformational to post-transformational wisdom. Some people may have the potential to follow this path but do not. Some simply give up, but others become partially transformational, in particular, self-transformational, other-transformational, para-transformational, or generally transformational. And still others follow a deviated path and become pseudo-transformational, turning their transformational capabilities in a foolish or toxic direction (Sternberg, 2018b).

Table 7. Impediments to the realization of transformationally wise behavior in the everyday world.

Impediment	Example of impediment	Possible work-around to impediment
People are selfish and often narcissistic	Given a choice between a career helping others at modest compensation and a career indifferent to, or harming others, for large compensation, many will choose the latter	Find ways to shape the job more to help others; find a different job; engage in an activity outside work that helps others
People often seek gains only for their own group (people like themselves), not for other groups	In many countries, political or other parties encourage zero-sum thinking whereby gains for one group are presented as losses to another group	Show that achieving a common good will benefit everyone in the long run, although not necessarily in the short-run; without a common-good solution, conflicts continue to simmer or result in outright hostilities, seemingly without end
People often prefer toxicity in ideas, which are then disguised as beneficence	Toxic leaders present simple, superficially appealing pseudo-solutions that are alleged to benefit their followers and to put others in their proper (inferior) place	People often have a just-world hypothesis, but their just world often results in great benefits for them and great harms to others (e.g. slavery, misogynistic treatment of women, racist or xenophobic treatment of others) and so they need to realize that often the world is not just, much as we might wish it to be
Wise solutions are elusive to find, and often no solution to a real problem seems all that wise	When individuals or groups have widely disparate interests (e.g. create an independent Palestinian state or not), almost any solution will seem inadequate rather than wise	Toxic leaders create mindsets that present as wise only their own solutions, and even those solutions, in practice, quickly show themselves to be unwise; young people need to be shown that one-sided thinking about problems is inadequate
Wise solutions often are difficult to implement because of cost, lack of resources, opposition, or all of these	Despite the risks of weapons of mass destruction, there is great opposition to disarmament for fear that one will give a possibly fatal advantage to one's foes	Victims or war, extreme poverty, homelessness, etc., need food, housing, and safety, but many governments do not allocate the resources that are needed to meet their needs; societies that meet the needs of all their citizens can provide stability and wellbeing to all, not just to the privileged
Solutions that appear to be wise to some often are one-sided solutions in disguise	America-First or any-country-first solutions fail to take into account the economic, political, and cultural connections between countries in a highly interconnected world	Help people realize that their interests are interconnected with, and dependent upon the interests of others, including others unlike them, whether they wish that to be the case or not

(continued)

Table 7. (Continued)

Impediment	Example of impediment	Possible work-around to impediment
Wise solutions almost never please everyone, especially in the short-term, and cannot honestly be presented as though they were pleasing to all	Any partial solution to the global climate-change crisis will hurt some interests in the short-term, and those interests may oppose a viable long-term solution	Most people want to stop or at least slow down global climate change but are unwilling to make the sacrifices needed to turn things around; they need to see that their unwillingness will hurt future generations and already is hurting their own generation
What is perceived to be wise at one time ceases to be perceived as wise at another	Wars almost always seem more attractive before they are initiated than after they are initiated and the staggering costs are appreciated	As a conflict goes on, one's allies may act in ways that one finds increasingly distasteful or unacceptable, but once one has accepted them as allies, it is difficult to say "enough is enough"; yet, sometimes entities need to make the case for a new approach to a conflict that has reached a stalemate
What is perceived to be wise in one place is not viewed as wise in another	Wearing of hijabs can be seen as expressions of appropriate modesty in one place or among one group but as intrusive on women's autonomy in another place or among another group	Accept national and cultural differences as a normal part of human existence but insist that those differences do not infringe on the rights and liberties of any involved parties
The people chosen for leadership positions are often chosen not for wisdom but rather for other traits that are indifferent to or incompatible with wisdom	Increasingly, leaders are being chosen for performative characteristics rather than for the wisdom-based quality of their performance; often, the performances are toxic, appealing to people's worst instincts	The "Golden Calf" phenomenon is as widespread today as in ancient times, with people seeking false gods to worship, perhaps while simultaneously believing themselves to be doing the opposite; people need to learn to recognize their own hypocrisy as well as that of others

Wisdom has long been seen as comprising a set of characteristics that all wise people have. Various researchers have provided diverse lists of important characteristics of wisdom (for example, Ardelt, 2003, 2004; Grossmann, Weststrate, Ardelt, et al., 2020; Leeman et al., 2022; Webster, 2003, 2007). However, possession of those characteristics does not necessarily guarantee that the person is willing to use the characteristics as tools to create meaningful changes in the world by being devoted to the attainment of a common good. There are many impediments to the implementation of fully transformational wisdom, as shown in Table 7. Many of the problems we face in the world stem not from a lack of people with wise personal characteristics but rather, from a lack of individuals using these characteristics for collective benefits (Sternberg, 2023). Transformational wisdom is manifested through action. Some people think the transformationally wise thoughts and talk the transformationally wise talk, but do not walk the transformationally wise walk.

In this essay, we have suggested that wisdom is not a static or singular concept. People have

different kinds of wisdom directed toward the goal of making wise decisions. We have distinguished two broad kinds of wisdom- transactional and transformational wisdom, which are different in kind and often in outcomes.

Transactionally wise people make wise decisions in return for some kind of reward, usually, an immediate one. This exchange can be related to building good relationships with others or improving the work quality. In contrast, transformationally wise people seek to make constructive and transformative changes and inspire others to make such changes in the world. They thus use their wisdom to inspire people and to pursue the common good. Transformational wisdom can vary based on the person's characteristics, the problem they seek to solve, and the situational context in which they seek to solve it. There are various kinds of partially transformational wisdom in addition to fully transformational wisdom. The world needs fully transformational wisdom. But the world does not get enough of it. It is up to all of us to give it more.

A society without transformationally wise people may become stuck. It may experience stagnation, as we often can see in the world we live in now. We need to develop in our children the skills and attitudes that later will enable them to make the transformationally wise decisions that will gradually make the world a better place to live.

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